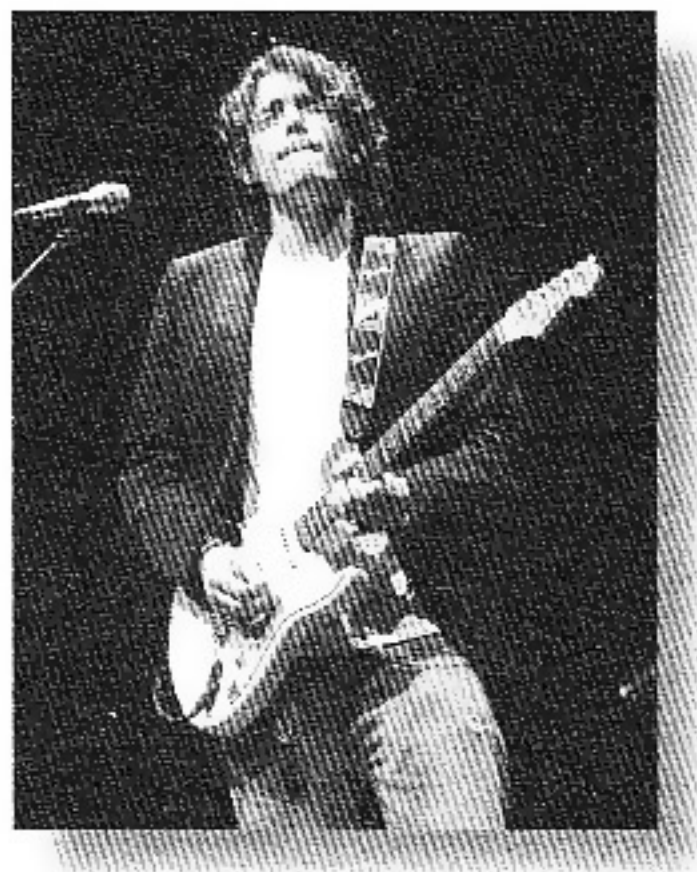


27 IDOLS, CELEBRITIES AND FAMOUS PERSONALITIES



"A celebrity is a person who works hard all his life to become well-known, then wears dark glasses to avoid being recognised."

Fred Allen

"Let every man be respected as an individual and no man idolised."

Albert Einstein

□ VOCABULARY INPUT

Dealing with this topic you will come across the following vocabulary. Read it and look up the unknown words in your dictionary.

- **human traits/characteristics/features/qualities:**
- **positive:** brave, bright, charismatic, charming, courageous, energetic, generous, hardworking, honest, loyal, open-hearted, patient, reliable, respectful, responsible, sympathetic, trusting, trustworthy, willing
- **negative:** arrogant, aggressive, brutal, careless, cruel, hypocritical, malicious, reluctant, selfish, thoughtless, vain
- **values:** love, faith, health, respect, family, friendship, commitment, security, education, freedom, money, career, peace
- **idols:** pseudo-idol, ideal person, to idealise/idolise, icon, example, hero/heroine, role model, celebrity, ordinary people
- **heroes/heroines:** ancient, literary, fictional, national, war
- **celebrities:** actors/actresses, singers, musicians, sportsmen/sportswomen, politicians, writers
- **role models/pop idols:**
 - admired, adored, artificial, criticised, famous, idealised, influential, overrated, popular, stylish, in the lime-light, well-known
- **ordinary people:** to perform extraordinary acts, to possess human qualities, to gain respect, to do brave/heroic acts
- **activities/acts:**
 - to admire, to identify with, to save life, to promote peace, to sacrifice, to fight for freedom, to lead a campaign, to publicise, to encourage, to perform extraordinary acts, to support;
 - to betray, to criticise, to deny, to disappoint, to judge, to abuse political power, to be imprisoned, to overestimate

□ DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

Before reading the text, discuss the following questions in class.

1. How can one become a famous personality?
2. Who are the most famous personalities in your country? What are they famous for?
3. How would you describe an idol? Why do people need them?
4. What human traits do you consider negative?
5. What traits do you admire?
6. What talent contests are popular in your country?
7. Do you admire ordinary people? What for?
8. What makes celebrities popular?
9. Do you think that some crimes are committed because of films?
10. Name some Slovak national heroes (dead or alive) and say what they are famous for.

□ TEXT

Read the texts below in silence. Check the meaning of the words in bold and answer the questions below.

WHO ARE IDOLS?

The concept of an **idol** [Greek: eidolon = "appearance"] **appears** very often in religion and philosophy. Several philosophers, such as *Aristotle*, *Plato*, *Bacon* and *Nietzsche*, developed concepts that they have called idols. We can say that an **ideal** person does not exist because every individual possesses both positive and negative traits. We try to develop the positive traits and **suppress** the negative ones. Every society and every individual believes in a certain **hierarchy of values**. Love, health, **faith**, family and friendship are usually among the top values. Some people consider money and career the most important ones. A similar hierarchy of values is important for a good relationship.

1. Who are idols according to the ancient philosophers?
2. According to the text, does an ideal person exist? Explain.

ROLE MODELS – IDOLS OR "PSEUDO-IDOLS"?

During **adolescence**, young people often search for a **unique** identity. At this age, sportsmen and sportswomen, rock stars and film and television performers (e. g. reality show stars) become **role models** for them. Teenagers often wish to be like their chosen role models who have **achieved great popularity** through the publicity they have received from the mass media. The *MTV* music channel is one of the channels that has helped many stars become idols. Idols are **well-known** in society and **receive attention** from

a large number of people. They are usually young and always look good and **stylish**. They have their own fashion designers and stylists. Their popularity does not usually last a very long time. They are part of a marketing **campaign** which ensures that the mass media regularly informs the **public** about their idols' lives. This type of information **is not always based on reality** and is often **made up**. Role models are often **criticised**. *Pop Idol* is the most famous talent **contest** which aims to find the best new young singer or pop idol in a given country. It combines a traditional talent show format with some aspects of reality television shows. **Viewers vote** for their idols by mobile phone **text messages**. These types of idols have a great **influence** on people of a certain age. Young people try to **resemble** them by copying the way they look and behave. Teenagers often find their idols in reality shows. Reality show stars are "pseudo-idols", which means they are not real idols. They are often **overrated** and **admired** for no good reasons.

3. What qualities do the role models often admired by the young have?
4. Describe *Pop Idol* using the information from the text above.

WHO ARE REAL HEROES?

In modern history, we often speak about heroes. A **hero (male)** or **heroine (female)** is an extraordinary character who represents the most important **traits valued** by the culture they are in. The hero is **idealised** and often **possesses** superhuman characteristics. These **enable** him or her to **perform extraordinary acts** for which he or she is famous. Heroes are also people who have difficult or challenging jobs, such as **volunteers** in regions of war or natural catastrophes, fire-fighters, soldiers and doctors. The qualities we admire include **courage**, talent, energy, charm, a **sense of humour**, etc. Every year, we hear about people who have saved somebody's life or done some other **brave** act that had required a great deal of courage. They saved people who had nearly **drowned** or had been **injured** in a car accident. They gave blood or performed very difficult **surgery**. In our country, every year, one of these heroes is given an award for "the bravest act of the year".

5. How are heroes defined in the text above?
6. What kind of qualities in the text above are applied to heroes?

WHO ARE FICTIONAL HEROES?

Apart from real existing heroes, there are also **fictional** heroes – heroes from books, films and plays. Characters in books often become idols admired by generations of readers. Every nation's literature has such idols. When a book is filmed, they can become film heroes. In modern movies, many heroes are **charismatic** and are **adored** by viewers. Women like handsome, brave male heroes; men like attractive female heroes. In some films, heroes are ordinary people who try to **overcome obstacles** in their lives and often

change during the story. People can **identify with** them because they are realistic and they **remind** them **of** their own lives. Through these characters they can understand life better. Some heroes, mostly in science fiction or action films, possess superhuman characteristics. These heroes are very appealing for children and the young. There are heroes who are very violent and consider **violence** a way to solve all problems. Adults criticise violent heroes from movies and computer games, saying that violence has a very negative **impact** on their children. Their children can easily identify themselves with these heroes and start to **behave** in a similar way. Many **crimes** have been **committed as a result of** such films.

7. Why do some people identify with fictional heroes?
8. Why do violent heroes have a negative impact on children?

ORDINARY PEOPLE – OUR IDOLS?

Most of us admire people who are **not at all** famous but are **ordinary**. **Still**, they are idols for us because they represent certain human traits that we admire and often do not possess. Our parents, grandparents, siblings or friends are idols for us. When we are children, we admire them because they always help us or **because of** their profession. When we grow up, we admire them because they are not afraid to fight against difficulties in their lives, they help other people or **simply** always have a smile on their faces. Without realising it, any of us might be a hero for somebody who respects us for a certain quality.

9. Which ordinary people can become our idols?
10. What do we admire them for?

□ VOCABULARY LIST

to admire – obdivovať
adolescence – adolescencia
to adore – zbožňovať
apart from – okrem
to appear – zjaviť sa
because of – kvôli
to behave – správať sa
brave – statočný, odvážny
campaign – kampaň
contest – súťaž
courage [kʌrɪdʒ] – odvaha
to criticise – kritizovať
to drown – utopiť sa
to enable – umožniť
faith – viera, dôvera
female – ženský
fictional – vymyslený
hero – hrdina
heroine – hrdinka
hierarchy of values – hierarchia hodnôt
charismatic – charizmatický
ideal – ideálny
to idealise (AmE: idealize) [aɪ'di:əlaɪz], idolise
 – idealizovať
to identify with [aɪ'dentɪfaɪ] – stotožniť sa s
idol [aɪdl] – idol
impact – dopad
to influence – ovplyvniť
to injure – poraniť sa
to make up – vymyslieť
male – mužský
not at all – vôbec
ordinary – bežný

to overrate – preceniť, nadhodnotiť
to possess – vlastniť, mať
public – verejnosť
to remind of – pripomenúť
to resemble – pripomínať
role model – vzor, príklad
sense of humour (AmE: humor) – zmysel
 pre humor
simply – jednoducho
still – aj tak, napriek tomu
stylish – štýlový
to suppress [sə'pres] – potlačiť
surgery [sɜ:dʒəri] – operácia
text message – textová správa
trait – črta, vlastnosť
unique [ju'ni:k] – jedinečný
to value – ceniť si
viewer – divák
violence – násilie
volunteer – dobrovoľník
to vote – voliť
well-known – všeobecne známy

to achieve great popularity – dosiahnuť
 obrovskú popularitu
as a result of – v dôsledku
based on reality – na základe skutočnosti
to commit a crime – spáchať zločin
to overcome obstacles – prekonať prekážky
to perform extraordinary acts – robiť
 mimoriadne skutky
to receive attention – dostávať pozornosť

□ VOCABULARY PRACTICE

Task 1 Explain the meaning of the following human traits. Which of them do you admire most? Why?

Example: A friendly person is somebody who has got many friends.

1. A respectable person is somebody who...
2. A selfish person is somebody who...
3. A brave person is somebody who...
4. A smart person is somebody who...

5. A violent person is somebody who...
6. A charismatic person is somebody who...
7. A courageous person is somebody who...
8. An ordinary person is somebody who...
9. An idealised person is somebody who...
10. An overestimated person is somebody who...

Task 2 What do we call a person who...?

Example: plays the piano – pianist

1. is in politics – _____
2. writes music – _____
3. does sport professionally – _____
4. works in the field of science – _____
5. creates fine art – _____
6. sings – _____
7. leads an orchestra – _____
8. invents something new – _____
9. saves people from fires – _____
10. helps others in need for free – _____